

Situation ethics is a helpful method of moral decision-making.

Situation ethics is a system of morality which was developed by Joseph Fletcher in the 20th century, which he labelled the 'New Morality' in an attempt to combat the overly legalistic rules of traditional Christian ethics by developing a more nuanced, flexible approach to ethics based on the principle of love. In this essay, it will be argued that Situation Ethics is not a helpful method of moral decision-making as it fails to provide a convincing interpretation of human nature which leads to a robust moral framework and being practically applicable to ethical dilemmas.

The primary aspect of Fletcher's Situation Ethics is asserted in his six propositions, in which he states that love is the sole intrinsic good. For this reason, Fletcher builds his ethical framework on a 'law of love' which revolves around the pragmatic application of agape - this is the Christian definition of selfless love, so we should avoid legalistic ethical rules and instead follow a complex and dynamic process of morality which centres around this sole principle.

However, Fletcher's definition of the good is flawed as it overestimates the value of the Christian definition of selfless love in a way that does not align with an empirically valid biological understanding of human nature. When considering what kind of love humans should use to guide their ethical decision-making, this should always be aligned with our biological nature. Dawkins for instance provided scientific evidence that it is impossible for humans to behave in a way that is entirely selfless at all times as we naturally possess the selfish gene, making us biologically inclined towards self-serving intentions in a way that is encoded into our DNA. Dawkins suggested that this should be embraced as it has proven necessary to our survival by giving us the biological advantage to become the dominant species on this planet. Therefore, any ethical system which denies this intrinsic human nature is unconvincing as it is unnatural. If we are unable to detach our biological identities from our ethical decision-making,

then Fletcher's account should be rejected in principle because it is based on a flawed conception of human nature which cannot provide the basis for a robust moral framework.

Fletcher might respond to this criticism by arguing that even if selfless love is not a part of our basic nature, it is something that we must train ourselves towards prioritising as love is a positive principle which leads to a better world when applied selflessly. For instance, while the selfish gene may have initially given us a survival advantage this is no longer necessary in a modern context and can instead lead to problematic conclusions if we always focus on serving our own desires. For instance, while we may desire to buy fast fashion, this is detrimental to the environment in the long term and will negatively impact the whole of humanity. Therefore, selfless love may be a necessary ethical principle even if it is not aligned with human nature.

In spite of this defence, Fletcher's assumption that selfish love always leads to negative consequences is problematic as it fails to address the impact which denial of the self can have on the individual, which inevitably has a ripple effect on the whole of society. Nietzsche, for example, argued that the Christian concept of selfless love promotes a "life-denying" morality in which people are taught to repress their self-motivated desires - those which he argues are life affirming and should be embraced in order to enable true human flourishing. So, focusing on the love of oneself can be just as morally valuable as selfless love as if people are encouraged to cultivate themselves then they can become virtuous individuals who reflect their own self-love onto the world around them, with the abundance of love within themselves enabling them to become better people. If focusing solely on self love is life-denying, then this means that one who does not love himself could never truly love those around him, thus undermining the moral framework of Fletcher's Situation Ethics by demanding the inclusion of self-love in the definition of good. Therefore, Fletcher's Situation Ethics fails to provide a robust moral

framework as it is based upon an unworkable conception of the definition of the good, and is thus not a helpful moral theory.

Another important aspect of Joseph Fletcher's Situation Ethics is its flexibility. In his four working principles, Fletcher stresses the importance of situationism and pragmatism in ethical decision making. Fletcher believed that legalistic, prescriptive rules fail to recognise the uniqueness of every situation, in which circumstances will always differ and this should be taken into consideration when deciding on a course of moral action. For instance, in the case of a dangerous pregnancy that is likely to put the mother's life at risk, abortion should be allowed due to the olive nature of the situation rather than placing a blanket judgement which disallows abortions in all circumstances. Thus Fletcher anticipated criticisms that the vagueness of situation ethics means that it is practically unworkable asserting that this vagueness is a strength in reality as it avoids a one-size fits all approach to law-making and is personal, placing the wellbeing of those involved at the heart of decision-making. Fletcher drew on the teachings of William Temple, who argued that "what acts are right may depend on the circumstances" but we have a duty to always do what is right on a situational basis.

However, situation ethics still fails to provide a helpful method of moral decision-making as it allows moral agents to have excessive freedom. This can lead to dangerous consequences which may contradict Fletcher's 'law of love', meaning that it is not prescriptive as it fails to provide a workable method of moral decision-making that can be applied to practical contexts. For example, R. M. Hare argued that universal principles can be specific as complex situations can utilise nuanced moral principles. An example of this is the idea that no-one should kill another person, except where doing so will eliminate a brutal system of government. This allows for prescriptive ethical guidelines to be set out while taking into account the specificity of situations, avoiding the problem of undermining ethical principles which Fletcher's

philosophy might lead to. Nonetheless, Fletcher would argue that Situation Ethics is still a helpful method of moral decision-making as history has shown that people have become educated and civilised over time such as through banning the slave trade and introducing fundamental rights in the wake of the horrors of WW2. So, Fletcher argued that his morality reflects the fact that people can be trusted with more freedom.

In spite of this defence, it remains true that Situation Ethics places excessive power in the hands of the individual due to its subjective definition of love which can be applied to moral contexts in a dangerous manner. William Barclay, for instance, argued that Situation Ethics is dangerous as in order for freedom to be good, love has to be perfect - if there is not enough love then freedom forces the risk of becoming cruelty. Barclay's argument is successful because even though people might appear to have improved in modern times, excessive freedom to choose to do what they believe is the most loving thing could be a corrupting force. Therefore, Situation Ethics' lack of prescriptive moral principles is a fatal flaw as it means that it is unworkable in a practical context.